than two children, the population will shrink. We are already in deficit, many youngsters are migrating to other countries and our villages are becoming empty.... Everyone must act responsibly, not just for themselves but for the country as well." Incidentally, the two-child norm was introduced in 1994 when he was CM of undivided Andhra Pradesh. So convinced is Naidu that he now wants to make it mandatory that only those candidates who have two or more children can fight elections.

The population push also has an economic and political imperative. As in the other southern states, there is a fear of losing the present numerical share in Parliament after the next delimitation exercise (which should follow the delayed decennial Census that is likely to be initiated in 2025). Besides the apportioning of Lok Sabha seats, the devolution of funds, too, is based on population size. On both fronts, therefore, all southern states are deeply worried at the prospect that their success in stabilising population growth could actually end up being "penalised" by the Centre. Lower allocation of central funds is already causing a lot of heartburn in the South. The risk of reduced political representation will only add fuel to the fire.

SO CONVINCED IS NAIDU THAT HE NOW WANTS TO REVERSE THE LAW: ONLY CANDIDATES WITH TWO OR MORE CHILDREN WILL BE ABLE TO FIGHT THE POLLS

The government's demographic experts call it a welcome move for another reason: the two-child norm, they point out, has always tended to have an "anti-women, anti-poor" effect. Studies on the impact of the two-child policy have highlighted that it often led to adverse consequences, actually enforcing gender discrimination through forced abortions of female foetuses. Such policies, when strictly enforced, also disproportionately burden or penalise the poor as they have less access to family planning services, they say.

Poonam Muttreja, executive director at the Population Foundation of India (PFI), concedes "regressive approaches (like the two-child norm) must be rejected" but is not in favour of the approach taken by Naidu. Southern states like Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and Kerala have achieved lower fertility rates due to investments in education, healthcare and women's empowerment, she points out. "Naidu's call for women to have more children threatens decades of progress in population stabilisation and women's empowerment. It also ignores women's health and aspirations while reinforcing outdated gender stereotypes," cautions Muttreja.

So what is the way forward? Southern states should recognise the potential of a 'longevity or silver dividend'—encouraging older adults to remain economically active while the state provides robust healthcare and social support systems. Also, given India's demographic diversity, differential programmes are essential. "In the more advanced southern states, policies should focus on addressing ageing populations, improving childcare infrastructure and creating supportive environments for migrant workers. In contrast, northern states, which are still catching up in demographic transition, must prioritise universal access to quality reproductive health services, education and vocational skills for youth," explains Muttreja.

Naidu's 'more children' idea got support from an unlikely quarter with RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat echoing the idea, saying "Hindu women should have three children" to redress the population "imbalance". Incidentally, the state BJP, an ally in Naidu's government, had distanced itself from the CM's statement when it first came out. ■



By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

In Petrapole, West Bengal, India's busiest land crossing with Bangladesh, a truck carrying cotton yarn rumbled across the border. At the wheel for this sortie across from Petrapole land port was Annapoorni Rajkumar, a woman from Tamil Nadu. What made this special wasn't just the landmark event of a woman driving a heavy goods vehicle across an international border from Bengal for the first time, but also the speed with which she completed her task. In just a few hours, Annapoorni returned after offloading her cargo in Benapole, in Bangladesh—an unheard of turnaround time.
The credit goes to the Suvidha portal, a digital vehicle facilitation system introduced by the Bengal government in collaboration with the Land Ports Authorities of India (LPAI), Indian Customs and the Border Security Force. The portal has redefined trade at Bengal's six international check posts (ICPs)—Petrapole and Ghojadanga in North 24 Parganas, Mahadipur in Malda, Hili in Dakshin Dinajpur, Changrabandha in Coochbehar and Fulbari in Jalpaiguri. Faster trade has brought financial benefits—the state government recently announced that it has earned Rs 600 crore in revenue since the inception of the